# Chuckles vs. Whispers

An empirical study evaluating sensory discernment and brand perception between Woolworths Chuckles and Cadbury Whispers. Two unlabelled bags were prepared: Bag 1 contained Whispers, and Bag 2 contained Chuckles. Twenty-five participants completed a blind tasting to identify the treats and record their preference.




Bag 1: Cadbury Whispers (Purple) • Bag 2: Woolworths Chuckles (Red)

## 1. Sensory Discernment vs. Identification

The primary hypothesis posited that consumers cannot tell the difference between Chuckles and Whispers on taste alone. The data reveals a clear separation between physical sensory contrast and brand identification.

While 72% of participants (18 of 25) clearly perceived a difference between the two bags, only 52% (13 of 25) correctly named both treats. An additional 20% (5 of 25) tasted a distinct difference but had the brand names completely backwards. People can feel the textural contrast, but correctly identifying which one is Woolworths and which is Cadbury is essentially a coin toss.

**Sensory Contrast Perceived**
72% of participants (18 of 25) knew the bags were different

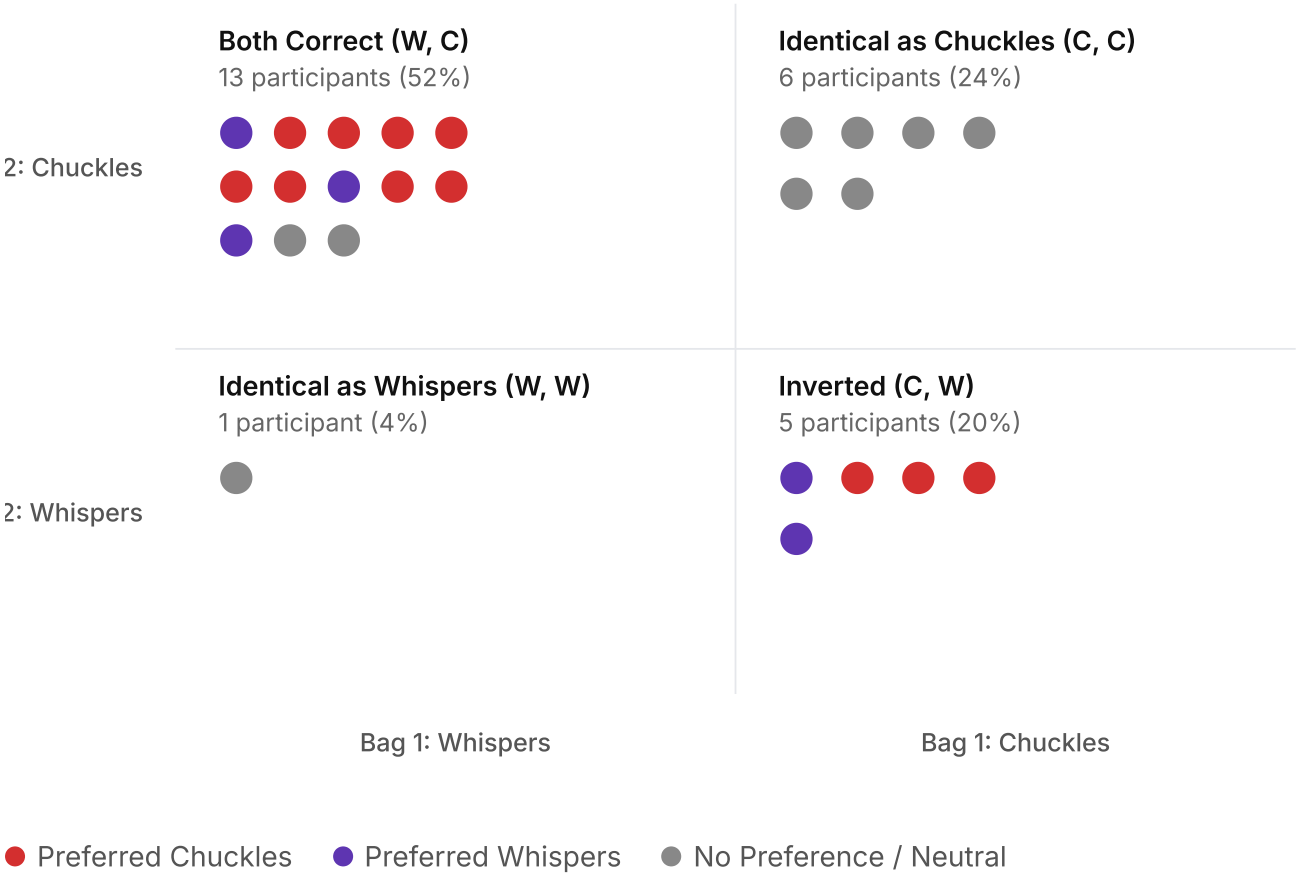



**Accurate Brand Naming**
Only 52% of participants (13 of 25) correctly identified both bags




### Quadrant Distribution of Guesses

Each participant is mapped by their combined guess for Bag 1 and Bag 2. Dot colors indicate their true taste preference.




## 2. The Accurate Tasters

When participants have the sensory ability to accurately distinguish which chocolate is which, does their preference remain split?

Among the 13 participants who correctly named both bags, 11 expressed a definitive taste preference. Of those 11, 9 participants (81.8%) chose Chuckles. When the palate can reliably identify the products, Chuckles dominates by more than a four-to-one ratio.

**Preferences of Correct Identifiers (n = 11 with preference)**

9 chose Chuckles (81.8%) • 2 chose Whispers (18.2%)



**9 : 2 Ratio for Chuckles**

## 3. The Brand Expectation Bias

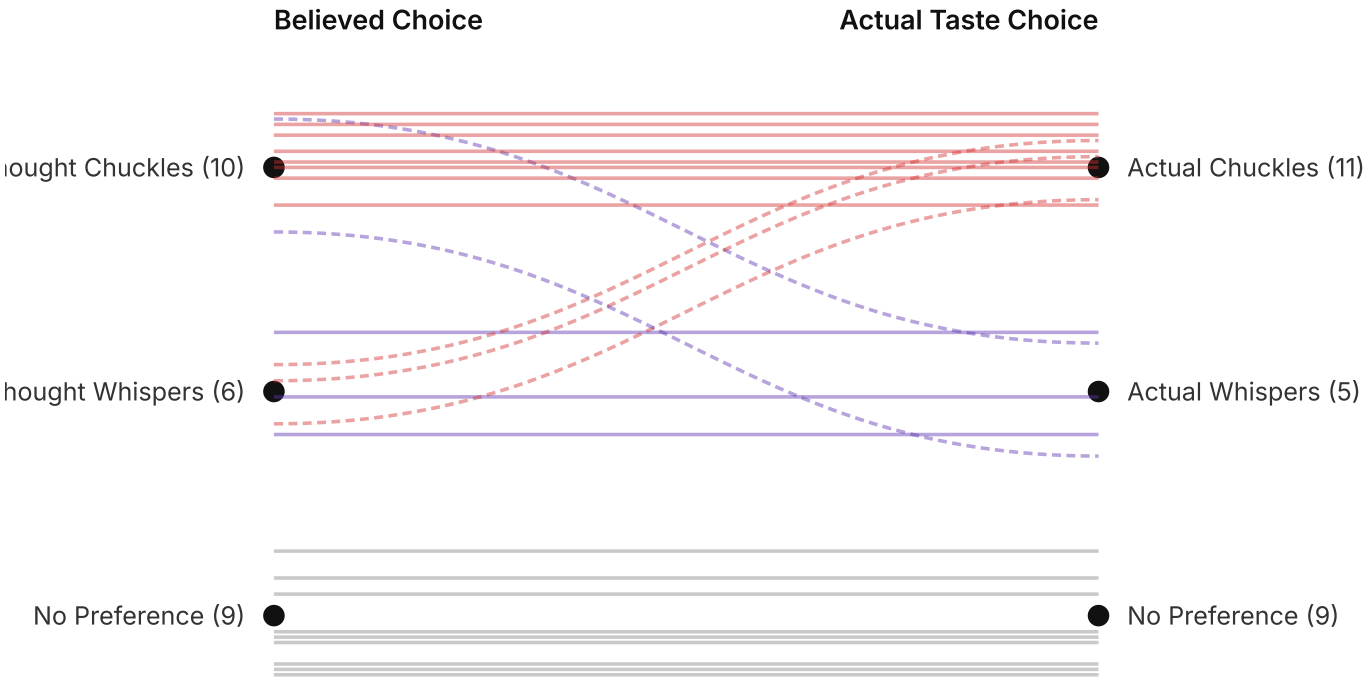
The second hypothesis examined whether participants would favor whichever bag they believed to be Chuckles. The data confirms a noticeable halo effect.

Out of the 16 participants who recorded a preference, 62.5% (10 of 16) preferred whichever bag they believed was Chuckles. Consumers intuitively associate higher taste enjoyment with the premium

brand, even when their identification is mistaken.

### Perception vs. Reality Trajectories

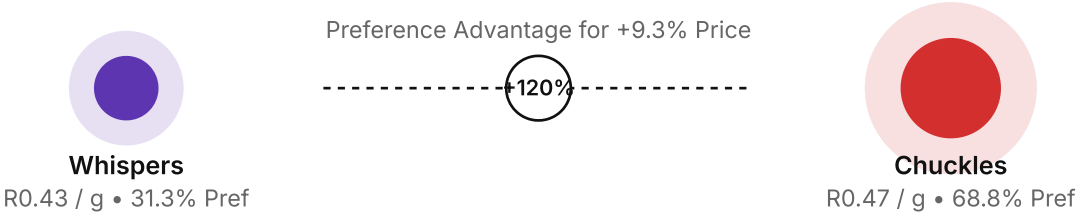
The lines below connect what participants believed they were choosing (left) to the true brand they actually tasted (right). Dashed lines highlight participants whose mental perception contradicted their physical preference.




## 4. The Economic Verdict

Chuckles retails at roughly R0.47 per gram, compared to R0.43 per gram for Whispers—a price premium of approximately 9.3%. In blind testing, Chuckles captured 68.8% of all expressed preferences (11 vs. 5).

A modest 9.3% price difference yields more than double the preference share (+120% preference advantage), demonstrating that the Woolworths premium is validated by physical taste rather than marketing alone.



## 5. The Cognitive Default

When participants could not detect any difference between the two bags, they overwhelmingly defaulted to assuming both were Chuckles.

Of the 7 participants who perceived the bags as identical, 6 guessed both were Chuckles (C-C) and only 1 guessed both were Whispers (W-W). Notably, 100% of these 7 participants registered no preference (Na), confirming that respondents reported honestly whenever their palate detected no contrast.

**Default Assumption Among Identical Guesses (n = 7)**




## 6. Demographic Accuracy and Decisiveness

The data revealed a pronounced sensory gap across gender. Women exhibited both sharper taste identification (+27 percentage points accuracy) and higher preference decisiveness.

Women identified both bags correctly at 71.4% (5 of 7), compared to 44.4% (8 of 18) for men. Furthermore, 85.7% of women expressed a decisive taste preference (with 83.3% choosing Chuckles), whereas 44.4% of men were indifferent and reported no preference.

**Women (n = 7)**

Identification Accuracy:

**71.4%** (5 of 7) Chuckles Preference Rate: **83.3%** Men (n = 18) Identification Accuracy: **44.4%** (8 of 18) Indifference Rate (No Preference): **44.4%**